

DSAT Practice — Overall Structure

25 Original MCQs | Questions Only

Q1.

[Easy]

Architect Mireya Solano is best known for designing sustainable housing in arid climates. Her early work focused on passive cooling techniques that reduced energy consumption by as much as 60 percent. More recently, Solano has expanded her practice to include large-scale urban planning projects that incorporate green corridors and rainwater harvesting infrastructure, earning her international recognition as a leader in climate-adaptive design.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It contrasts two architects' philosophies, describes a shared project, and then assesses its impact.
 - B) It presents a problem in architecture, evaluates two proposed solutions, and then endorses one over the other.
 - C) It introduces a figure, describes an early focus of her career, and then notes how her work has since broadened.
 - D) It explains a scientific concept, provides a historical example, and then argues for its wider application.
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Q2.

[Easy]

For decades, marine biologists assumed that deep-sea corals grew at negligibly slow rates and therefore contributed little to reef formation. However, a 2019 study led by oceanographer Elias Varga demonstrated that certain cold-water coral species can grow up to 15 millimeters per year under nutrient-rich conditions. This finding suggests that deep-sea corals may play a larger role in oceanic ecosystems than scientists previously recognized.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes an earlier assumption, introduces a study that challenges it, and then notes the broader implication of the study's findings.
 - B) It presents a scientific debate, offers evidence supporting both sides, and then leaves the question unresolved.
 - C) It outlines a research methodology, identifies a flaw in the methodology, and then proposes an alternative approach.
 - D) It compares two species of coral, highlights a similarity between them, and then explains why that similarity is surprising.
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Q3.*[Easy]*

The Aymara people of the Andes have a distinctive conceptualization of time. Unlike many cultures, which associate the future with what lies ahead and the past with what lies behind, the Aymara place the past in front of them—because it has been seen—and the future behind them—because it remains unseen. Linguist Rafael Nunez documented this by analyzing Aymara speakers' gestures: when discussing past events, speakers consistently gestured forward, and when discussing future events, they gestured behind themselves.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It raises a question about linguistic diversity, proposes a hypothesis, and then acknowledges a limitation of the hypothesis.
 - B) It identifies a cultural practice, contrasts it with a more common convention, and then describes evidence supporting the observation.
 - C) It introduces a researcher, summarizes the researcher's career, and then evaluates the reception of the researcher's most influential work.
 - D) It explains a theory of cognition, notes that the theory has been widely accepted, and then describes recent objections to it.
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Q4.*[Easy]*

Cellist Nadia Ferreira gained early acclaim performing classical repertoire with major orchestras. Critics praised her interpretations for their emotional depth and technical precision. In 2021, however, Ferreira surprised audiences by releasing an album that blended baroque cello suites with electronic production. While some traditionalists objected, the album attracted a new, younger audience to classical music.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It chronicles a musician's entire career in chronological order and then evaluates her lasting influence on a genre.
 - B) It compares two musical genres, explains why one has declined in popularity, and then argues that the other could revitalize it.
 - C) It presents a controversy in the music industry, outlines two opposing viewpoints, and then resolves the controversy.
 - D) It introduces a musician, describes her initial reputation, and then discusses a departure from that reputation and its mixed reception.
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Q5.*[Easy]*

Many species of firefly produce bioluminescent flashes to attract mates. Each species has a distinct flash pattern—varying in duration, interval, and color—that helps individuals identify members of their own species in the dark. Researchers at the Tallahassee Entomological Institute have cataloged over forty unique flash patterns among firefly species in the southeastern United States alone.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It introduces a species, compares it with a related species, and then argues that the two should be reclassified.
 - B) It presents a hypothesis about animal communication, tests the hypothesis experimentally, and then reports inconclusive results.
 - C) It describes a behavior, explains the purpose and variation of that behavior, and then provides a detail that illustrates the extent of the variation.
 - D) It defines a technical term, gives a historical origin for the term, and then suggests the term is now outdated.
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Q6.*[Easy]*

In her 2018 study, sociologist Priya Chandran surveyed over 3,000 remote workers across twelve countries about their sense of professional belonging. Chandran found that remote workers who participated in at least one virtual social event per week reported significantly higher levels of team cohesion than those who did not. She concluded that informal digital interactions can partially offset the isolation that remote work often produces.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It identifies a workplace trend, argues that the trend is harmful, and then proposes a policy to address the harm.
 - B) It describes a study's methodology, presents a key finding, and then states the researcher's conclusion based on that finding.
 - C) It compares two research methodologies, explains why one is superior, and then applies it to a new context.
 - D) It introduces a sociological theory, describes a study that contradicts it, and then evaluates the theory's remaining strengths.
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Q7.

[Easy]

The ceramic traditions of the ancient Pueblo peoples of the American Southwest are notable for their geometric painted designs. These designs were not merely decorative: archaeologist Sandra Kinley has argued that specific motifs corresponded to clan identities, serving as markers of social affiliation during trade and ceremonial gatherings. Kinley's interpretation is supported by the observation that vessels bearing identical motifs are consistently found within the same residential clusters at excavated sites.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes an artistic tradition, presents a scholar's interpretation of its social function, and then cites evidence supporting that interpretation.
 - B) It compares two ancient civilizations' art forms, identifies a shared technique, and then questions whether the similarity is coincidental.
 - C) It traces the evolution of a craft, attributes its decline to a specific historical event, and then discusses modern revival efforts.
 - D) It introduces an archaeological site, catalogs the artifacts found there, and then disputes a previous dating of those artifacts.
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Q8.

[Easy]

Wind power is one of the fastest-growing sources of renewable energy worldwide. Turbines convert kinetic energy from wind into electricity, and modern designs can generate power at wind speeds as low as 3 meters per second. Denmark, a pioneer in wind energy, now derives more than half of its electricity from wind turbines, demonstrating that wind power can serve as a primary energy source for an entire nation.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It argues against a common energy policy, provides statistics to support the argument, and then recommends a specific alternative.
 - B) It introduces an energy source, explains how it works, and then provides a real-world example that demonstrates its viability.
 - C) It describes a technological limitation, explains how engineers overcame it, and then predicts future improvements.
 - D) It compares two renewable energy sources, identifies their respective drawbacks, and then proposes combining them.
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Q9.

[Medium]

Literary scholars have long debated whether the anonymous medieval poem *The Seafarer* should be read as a literal account of maritime hardship or as an allegory for spiritual pilgrimage. Those favoring the literal reading point to the poem's vivid descriptions of icy seas and physical suffering, while proponents of the allegorical interpretation emphasize the poem's closing passages, which shift from oceanic imagery to meditations on divine grace. More recently, critic Helena Voss has proposed that these readings need not be mutually exclusive: the poem's power, she argues, derives precisely from the tension between bodily experience and spiritual aspiration.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes an artistic movement, identifies its most representative work, and then evaluates the movement's lasting significance.
 - B) It introduces a poem, provides biographical details about its author, and then analyzes the poem's influence on later writers.
 - C) It outlines a scholarly disagreement, summarizes the evidence each side cites, and then presents a position that synthesizes elements of both sides.
 - D) It presents a historical mystery, eliminates several possible explanations, and then endorses the most recently proposed explanation.
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Q10.

[Medium]

Economists have traditionally measured national prosperity using gross domestic product, a metric that aggregates the market value of goods and services produced within a country's borders. Critics, however, note that GDP fails to capture many factors that affect citizens' quality of life, such as income inequality, environmental degradation, and access to healthcare. In response, several international organizations have developed alternative indices—such as the Inclusive Development Index and the Human Development Index—that incorporate these broader dimensions of well-being alongside economic output.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It introduces two competing economic theories, evaluates the predictive accuracy of each, and then recommends adopting a hybrid model.
 - B) It argues that a particular economic theory is flawed, proposes a replacement theory, and then tests the replacement against historical data.
 - C) It traces the historical development of a statistical tool, explains how the tool was originally intended to be used, and then shows how its use has changed over time.
 - D) It defines a widely used metric, identifies limitations of that metric, and then describes efforts to address those limitations through alternative measures.
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Q11.

[Medium]

The fruit fly *Drosophila melanogaster* has been a cornerstone of genetic research since Thomas Hunt Morgan's early twentieth-century experiments. Because fruit flies reproduce quickly and share a surprising number of genes with humans, they allow scientists to study processes like cell division and disease susceptibility in compressed timeframes. Recent advances in CRISPR gene-editing technology have made fruit flies even more valuable: researchers can now introduce precise genetic modifications and observe their effects within a single generation, accelerating the pace of discovery.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It presents a scientific breakthrough, credits the breakthrough to a specific researcher, and then discusses the ethical concerns it raises.
 - B) It introduces a research organism, explains why it is useful, and then describes how a new technology has enhanced its usefulness.
 - C) It compares two model organisms, explains why one has fallen out of favor, and then predicts which organism will replace it.
 - D) It defines a biological concept, provides a historical example of its application, and then argues that the concept is poorly understood.
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Q12.

[Medium]

Philosopher Martha Nussbaum has argued that literature cultivates moral imagination by requiring readers to inhabit perspectives radically different from their own. Reading a novel about a refugee's journey, for example, may deepen a reader's empathy for displaced populations in ways that statistics and policy reports cannot. Nussbaum acknowledges, however, that literature alone is insufficient for ethical development; without critical reflection on what one reads, the emotional responses that literature elicits may reinforce existing biases rather than challenge them.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It summarizes a philosophical debate, explains why one position has prevailed, and then predicts how the debate will evolve.
 - B) It criticizes a common educational practice, proposes an alternative approach, and then evaluates the feasibility of implementing the alternative.
 - C) It presents a philosopher's claim about literature's moral value, illustrates the claim with an example, and then introduces a qualification that limits the claim.
 - D) It introduces two philosophers' competing views on ethics, contrasts their methodologies, and then argues that one methodology is more rigorous.
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Q13.*[Medium]*

Urban heat islands—areas within cities that experience significantly higher temperatures than surrounding rural regions—pose growing public health risks as global temperatures rise. The primary driver of urban heat islands is the replacement of vegetation with impervious surfaces such as asphalt and concrete, which absorb and retain solar energy. While strategies like increasing tree canopy cover and installing reflective roofing materials have shown promise in reducing surface temperatures, implementation remains uneven: wealthier neighborhoods tend to receive green infrastructure investments at higher rates than lower-income communities do.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It identifies a phenomenon, explains its primary cause, acknowledges potential solutions, and then notes an inequity in how those solutions are applied.
 - B) It describes a natural disaster, traces its origins to a policy failure, and then proposes legislation to prevent future occurrences.
 - C) It compares two cities' approaches to a shared problem, evaluates the effectiveness of each approach, and then recommends a hybrid strategy.
 - D) It presents an environmental trend, disputes its significance, and then argues that resources should be redirected to more pressing issues.
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Q14.*[Medium]*

The underlined portion reads: 'Although Kovalenko's initial recordings received little airplay, they circulated widely among jazz musicians, who admired his unconventional use of dissonance.' Pianist Dmitri Kovalenko emigrated from Kyiv to Chicago in 1962 and began recording small-ensemble jazz sessions that blended Eastern European folk harmonies with bebop improvisation. Although Kovalenko's initial recordings received little airplay, they circulated widely among jazz musicians, who admired his unconventional use of dissonance. By the mid-1970s, Kovalenko's approach had influenced a generation of avant-garde jazz composers, and music historians now regard him as a pivotal figure in the genre's evolution.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It identifies a flaw in Kovalenko's early technique that he later corrected in response to critical feedback.
 - B) It provides biographical background that explains why Kovalenko chose to record in a particular musical style.
 - C) It presents a contrast between Kovalenko's commercial reception and his influence among fellow musicians that sets up the text's later discussion of his lasting impact.
 - D) It offers a personal anecdote that humanizes Kovalenko and invites sympathy from the reader.
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Q15.

[Medium]

The underlined portion reads: 'Honeybees are widely regarded as the most important insect pollinators of agricultural crops.' Honeybees are widely regarded as the most important insect pollinators of agricultural crops. However, a meta-analysis by entomologist Clara Reyes examined pollination data from 41 countries and found that wild bee species collectively pollinated a greater variety of crop plants than managed honeybee colonies did. Reyes's findings suggest that conservation of wild bee habitats may be at least as critical to global food security as the maintenance of commercial honeybee populations.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It identifies a limitation of the study that the researcher acknowledges later in the text.
 - B) It summarizes the main conclusion of the meta-analysis described in the text.
 - C) It provides a definition that is necessary for understanding the study's methodology.
 - D) It establishes a widely held view that the study discussed in the text calls into question.
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Q16.

[Medium]

Restorers working on a fifteenth-century altarpiece in a Florentine chapel discovered, beneath layers of later overpainting, a richly detailed landscape that had been hidden for centuries. Chemical analysis of the pigments revealed that the original artist had used an unusually expensive ultramarine blue derived from lapis lazuli—a material typically reserved for the most prestigious commissions. This finding prompted art historians to reconsider the altarpiece's provenance, suggesting it may have been commissioned by a wealthier patron than previously believed.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It chronicles the creation of an artwork, identifies the artist responsible, and then assesses the artwork's aesthetic significance.
 - B) It introduces a restoration technique, compares it with an older technique, and then argues that the newer technique produces more reliable results.
 - C) It describes a discovery made during restoration, presents a material detail revealed by analysis, and then explains the historical implication that scholars drew from that detail.
 - D) It presents a controversy about an artwork's authenticity, evaluates competing claims, and then resolves the controversy with new evidence.
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Q17.

[Medium]

The underlined portion reads: 'This acceleration, Nakamura notes, coincided with a period of rapid industrialization in coastal cities.' Geographer Yuki Nakamura has documented a marked increase in the rate of mangrove forest loss along Southeast Asian coastlines between 1990 and 2010. This acceleration, Nakamura notes, coincided with a period of rapid industrialization in coastal cities. She cautions, however, that correlation alone does not establish causation, and that other factors—including shrimp aquaculture expansion and rising sea levels—likely contributed to mangrove decline during the same period.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It identifies a temporal relationship that the researcher later qualifies by acknowledging additional contributing factors.
- B) It states the researcher's primary conclusion, which the rest of the text is devoted to supporting with evidence.
- C) It introduces a counterargument that undermines the study's central finding.
- D) It defines a key term that is essential to understanding the study's methodology.

Q18.

[Medium]

Behavioral economist Tariq Osman has demonstrated that people tend to overestimate the likelihood of events that receive extensive media coverage, such as airplane crashes, while underestimating the probability of more common but less sensationalized risks, such as household falls. Osman terms this pattern 'salience bias' and argues that it distorts both individual decision-making and public policy priorities. His research has been cited by public health officials advocating for increased funding for fall-prevention programs among elderly populations.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It summarizes a media study, criticizes its methodology, and then proposes a more rigorous research design.
 - B) It presents two competing theories of risk perception, tests each theory against empirical data, and then determines which theory is better supported.
 - C) It describes a public health crisis, traces the crisis to a failure of individual judgment, and then recommends a technological solution.
 - D) It introduces a researcher's finding about cognitive bias, names and defines the bias, and then describes a practical application of the research.
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Q19.*[Hard]*

Art critic Tomoko Arai has challenged the conventional view that Japanese woodblock prints influenced French Impressionism in only one direction. While it is well established that artists such as Monet collected ukiyo-e prints and adopted their compositional strategies—flattened perspective, asymmetric framing, and bold outlines—Arai demonstrates that the exchange was reciprocal. Analyzing prints produced in Yokohama during the 1870s, she shows that Japanese printmakers incorporated Impressionist techniques, including broken brushwork and atmospheric light effects, into traditional formats. The resulting hybrid works, Arai argues, complicate the narrative of Western artistic innovation by revealing that cross-cultural influence operated simultaneously in both directions.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It presents a critic's challenge to a one-directional model of artistic influence by providing evidence that influence flowed in both directions, and then articulates the broader implication of that evidence.
- B) It traces the development of a painting technique across two countries, credits a single artist with its invention, and then evaluates the technique's aesthetic merits.
- C) It contrasts two art critics' interpretations of a specific artwork, explains why one interpretation gained wider acceptance, and then predicts how future scholarship may resolve the disagreement.
- D) It describes a historical artistic movement, argues that the movement has been underappreciated, and then calls for increased institutional recognition of its contributions.

Q20.*[Hard]*

The underlined portion reads: 'an assumption that may not hold in ecosystems where apex predators have been removed.' Ecologists have long relied on the principle that trophic cascades—the indirect effects that predators exert on lower levels of a food chain—operate primarily from the top down: removing a top predator, for instance, allows herbivore populations to expand, which in turn depletes vegetation. Recent field studies in regions where apex predators were eradicated decades ago, however, suggest that compensatory mechanisms—such as increased competition among herbivores and shifts in plant community composition—can partially buffer ecosystems against the expected cascade effects. This resilience, ecologists caution, is context-dependent, an assumption that may not hold in ecosystems where apex predators have been removed only recently or where biodiversity is already low.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It provides an example of a compensatory mechanism that ecologists have observed.
 - B) It restates the central finding of the field studies discussed in the text.
 - C) It identifies the research question that motivated the field studies mentioned in the text.
 - D) It specifies conditions under which the resilience described earlier in the text may not apply.
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Q21.*[Hard]*

Neuroscientist Amara Okonkwo has proposed that the sensation of aesthetic chills—the tingling, goosebump-inducing response some people experience when listening to music—arises from a temporary mismatch between the brain's predictive model and the actual auditory input. According to Okonkwo, the brain continuously generates expectations about upcoming musical events; when those expectations are violated in a manner that is surprising yet ultimately coherent with the piece's harmonic structure, the resulting prediction error triggers a dopaminergic reward response. Critics of this model note that chills can also occur during highly predictable musical passages, such as a familiar song's climax, suggesting that factors beyond prediction error—including personal memories and learned associations—may also contribute to the experience.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes a medical condition, attributes it to a specific neurological deficit, and then outlines a course of treatment.
 - B) It introduces a neuroscientist's model of an aesthetic experience, explains the mechanism the model proposes, and then presents a criticism that suggests the model is incomplete.
 - C) It summarizes two experiments on music perception, compares their methodologies, and then argues that one experiment's results are more reliable.
 - D) It defines a psychological concept, traces its origin to a particular philosophical tradition, and then evaluates whether the concept remains useful in contemporary research.
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Q22.*[Hard]*

Political scientist Lucia Marin has observed that voter turnout in municipal elections across several Latin American democracies correlates not with the competitiveness of the race—as conventional models predict—but with the density of civic associations in a given district. Districts with more neighborhood councils, religious organizations, and cultural clubs tend to produce higher turnout even in uncontested races. Marin posits that these associations create 'mobilization networks' through which information about elections is disseminated and social pressure to vote is generated. She acknowledges, however, that her cross-sectional data cannot establish whether civic associations cause higher turnout or whether both variables are driven by a third factor, such as community socioeconomic status.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes a decline in voter participation, attributes the decline to a lack of competitive elections, and then proposes institutional reforms to reverse it.
 - B) It presents a researcher's observation that challenges a conventional model, offers a proposed explanation, and then acknowledges a methodological limitation that qualifies the explanation.
 - C) It compares voter behavior in two different types of elections, identifies a commonality, and then argues that the commonality is coincidental.
 - D) It introduces a policy initiative, evaluates its effectiveness using longitudinal data, and then recommends modifications to improve outcomes.
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Q23.*[Hard]*

The underlined portion reads: 'without making explicit the evaluative framework on which such judgments depend.' Literary theorist Kwame Asare has argued that contemporary book criticism would benefit from greater methodological transparency. In practice, Asare observes, most published reviews present interpretive judgments—claims about a novel's thematic coherence, emotional authenticity, or stylistic originality—as though they were self-evident, without making explicit the evaluative framework on which such judgments depend. By articulating their criteria openly, Asare contends, critics would not only strengthen their arguments but also invite more productive disagreement, since readers would be better positioned to identify exactly where and why their assessments diverge.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It characterizes a practice that Asare identifies as problematic and that motivates his call for greater transparency.
 - B) It describes the solution that Asare proposes to address the problem identified in the text.
 - C) It offers an example of a specific review that Asare cites to support his argument.
 - D) It concedes that Asare's proposal has a significant limitation that weakens his overall argument.
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Q24.*[Hard]*

Paleontologist Lena Vasquez recently reexamined a collection of fossilized trackways in Patagonia that had been attributed to a large theropod dinosaur. Using photogrammetric modeling to create three-dimensional maps of the tracks, Vasquez determined that the stride length, foot rotation, and depth of impression were more consistent with a giant ground-dwelling bird from the Cenozoic era than with any known Mesozoic theropod. If Vasquez's reinterpretation is correct, the trackways would represent the earliest evidence of avian gigantism in South America—a conclusion that, while provocative, awaits corroboration from skeletal remains that have yet to be discovered at the site.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A) It describes a reinterpretation of fossil evidence, explains the analytical basis for the reinterpretation, states its potential significance, and then notes a gap in the supporting evidence.
 - B) It presents a widely accepted classification, explains the criteria used to arrive at it, and then defends the classification against recent challenges.
 - C) It introduces a fieldwork methodology, compares it with traditional methods, and then argues that the new methodology should become the disciplinary standard.
 - D) It traces the discovery of a fossil species, describes the controversy it provoked, and then resolves the controversy by citing genetic evidence.
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Q25.

[Hard]

The underlined portion reads: 'To be sure, algorithmic curation does expose listeners to artists they might never have encountered otherwise.' Music industry analyst Jorge Fuentes has argued that streaming platforms' reliance on recommendation algorithms is homogenizing popular music. Because algorithms prioritize songs with features—such as short intros and repetitive hooks—that maximize listener engagement metrics, artists and producers face strong incentives to conform to a narrow sonic template. To be sure, algorithmic curation does expose listeners to artists they might never have encountered otherwise. Yet Fuentes maintains that this benefit is outweighed by the long-term cost: a reduction in the stylistic diversity that has historically driven musical innovation.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A) It restates the analyst's main conclusion in more accessible language for a general audience.
 - B) It introduces the central argument that the rest of the text is devoted to supporting with evidence.
 - C) It provides an example of a streaming platform feature that the analyst regards as particularly harmful.
 - D) It concedes a benefit of the practice being criticized before the text reasserts that the overall effect is negative.
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